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Mahbûbperest, *uranist* and *transvestite*: translating sexology in the Late Ottoman Empire and Early Republican Turkey

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ABSTRACT
This article examines the translation of sexological categories into Turkish during the late Ottoman Empire and Republican Turkey, focusing on how multiple frameworks for understanding desires, identities, and acts were negotiated. Through an intertextual reading of a psychiatric book by Mazhar Osman, a prominent name in the translation of sexological terms, the article examines categories of male homoeroticism and gender non-conformity. Tensions within European sexology were intertwined with late Ottoman views on male homoeroticism, which also contained its own conflicts. While translation of sexology intersected with efforts to create a monolingual Turkish nation, it simultaneously destabilised its sexual vocabulary by introducing 'foreign' taxonomies. Textual and real-life encounters between European and the Turkish-speaking sexual modernities shaped the translation process, which, in turn, were influenced by the structural inequalities of imperialism, nationalism, and cisheteropatriachy. Translation was not a simple transfer of concepts, but a multi-layered process in which the travel of ideas is intermingled with that of people, and carries in itself the potential of subversion of pathologising discourses. The paper concludes that tracing the complex nature of turn-of-the-century translations is essential for reclaiming an anti-imperialist queer critique in confronting anti-gender politics' instrumentalisation of anti-imperialist rhetoric.

KEYWORDS
Late Ottoman Empire; Republican Turkey; sexology; translation

Introduction: translation and the question of authenticity

In this paper, I examine the translation of sexological categories, during the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries by investigating how multiple frames of intelligibility for desires, identifications and acts were negotiated in translating modern sexual understandings. My analysis focuses on the 'sexual perversions' section of *Tabâbet-i Ruhîye* (Psychiatric Medicine), a work by prominent neuropsychiatrist Mazhar Osman which went through three editions from 1909 to the 1940s. Mazhar Osman belonged to a generation of medical doctors – mostly neuropsychiatrists and forensic doctors – who played a critical role in the translation of modern categories of sexuality and gender identity. I approach *Tabâbet-i Ruhîye* through an intertextual reading, focusing on categories of

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male same-sex sexuality,[1] as well as considering the translation of the category of 'transvestite'. While the book provides a lens to trace the evolving discourses of sexuality and gender identity in this period, the textual and real encounters surrounding it reveal how the specific socio-political and cultural context shaped the complex processes of translation. Thus, translation was not a straightforward transfer of regulatory taxonomies; it was a complex, multi-layered process in which the movement of ideas intersected with the movement of people, all shaped by an imperialist apparatus of scientific knowledge production.

Translation of sexology, a body of knowledge itself born out of translation, generated an interstitial space of contradiction where existing understandings of erotic lives and gendered subjectivities intersected with scientific conceptualisations of sexuality. In this space, translators of sexology recontextualised the tensions within European sexology, such as those between congenital and acquired characteristics or gender transitivity and sexual orientation, and coalesced them with the tensions within existing understandings of homoeroticism, such as the one between carnality and spirituality or the division between active and passive roles.

A growing body of literature focuses on the translation and appropriation of European sexual knowledge by non-Western countries in the nineteenth and twentieth centuries (Baer 2015; Bauer 2015; Chiang 2015; El Shakry 2017; Frühstück 2003; Fuechtner, Haynes, and Jones 2017; Kozma 2010; 2013; 2015; Rocha 2015). These studies complicate Michel Foucault's dichotomy, presented in *The History of Sexuality* and later revised, between *ars erotica* – erotic art – and *scientia sexualis* – sexual science–, for reinforcing the idea that modernity is inherently Western and for projecting timelessness onto the non-Western geographies of *ars erotica* (Al-Kassim 2008; Rocha 2015).[2] By examining the complex processes of negotiation, reappropriation, adaptation and recontextualisation involved in the translation of sexology, this literature challenges the assumption that the non-Western regions merely respond to the scientific language imposed by the West, whether through silencing, acceptance or rejection. The increasing emphasis on the cross-cultural nature of various sexual discourses shows that not only the imagined geographies of the non-West, but also the West translated, articulated, and negotiated non-native sexual discourses, if native discourses existed at all. European sexological theories themselves were products of translation where terms of classification emerged out of borrowings from Latin and Greek and practitioners transferred and reformulated concepts that originated in different languages (Bauer 2003, 383; 2009, 15–16). More importantly, colonialism and imperialism played a fundamental role in shaping scientific knowledge about sexuality (Marhoefer 2022; Stoler 1995). Sexology lacked a discursive unity; even within the supposed homogeneity of a single language, labels, definitions, and taxonomies were continually negotiated, revised, and adapted. These complex processes make it clear that sexology is not a Western endeavour but shaped by the transnational circulation and dissemination of concepts, ideas and people through various networks and less readily-traceable forms of textual interactions (Bauer 2009, 2015). In this process, interaction with different genres, especially with

[1]Female same-sex sexuality and how it was dealt in sexology literature as well as nineteenth–twentieth century prose narratives is a topic that requires a separate in-depth analysis. For a brief evaluation see Sarıtaş (2019, 2020).
[2]For a discussion of *ars erotica* see Franke (2012); Downham Moore (2023).

literature contributed to the formation and translation of sexology (Bauer 2009; Schaffner 2012).

Through an intertextual examination of *Tabâbet-i Ruhîye*, where terms and categories of 'sexual perversion' were translated, I hope to draw on and expand the above literature by using translation as a method to explore the complex relationships between the sexual modernities in Europe – particularly German speaking sexology – and the Turkish-speaking late Ottoman Empire and Republican Turkey and to map the textual as well as real-life encounters that shape the process. Ideas, theories, and concepts travel, and the 'processes of travel … shape the formation of ideas' (Bauer 2015, 9). The scientific journeys of Ottoman Turkish neuropsychiatrists to German-speaking countries, as well as the travels of individuals with non-normative gender and sexual identities to the Ottoman Empire were critical in the translation and transmission of scientific knowledge about sexuality into Turkish. Yet, as Edward Said argues, 'one should go on to specify the kinds of movement that are possible' (1983, 226). These movements were both shaped by and contributed to the structural inequalities of imperialism, politics of nationalism and cis-heteronormativity.

Highlighting the structural inequalities of imperialism is essential to reclaim anti-imperialist critique from its strategic reappropriation by populist right-wing governments – such as Turkey's AKP – whose anti-gender discourse and policies co-opt the rhetoric of anti-imperialism. Within this framework, any act of translation or usage of non-native terms is portrayed as an instrument of imperial imposition, while LGBTI + individuals and feminists are presented as foreign agents threatening a mythical hetero-patriarchal past and an untainted national language (Ünal 2023, 10). An alternative approach has been to foreground the shared colonial history of both heteronormative frameworks and subversive categories of sexual and gender nonconformity – a perspective advanced by several scholars over the past two decades. But despite its opposing political stance, this position shares a monolingual assumption indicating that if the vocabulary of a particular entity – be it an identity, a desire or an expression – is not indigenous, then that entity is not authentic to the geography in question. In criticising the use of non-native terms for gender and sexuality, such as LGBTI + or queer, as colonial effects, this line of thought usually traces their introduction into non-Western cultures through translation (Savcı 2021, 12–14). Joseph Massad, who has instigated the heated – and somewhat tired – discussions of an imperialist 'gay international' describes the process as follows:

> [T]he more recent imperial export of the homo-hetero binary—and specifically of gay and lesbian identities—takes place in a context that has already *suffered* a prior process of translation. This process produced particular 'peripheral' understandings of normative and natural desires, *inflected* with western medical and scientific arguments and taxonomies, but which mostly *failed to institute a replica* of the western regime of sexuality. (Massad 2013; italics belong to me)

In suggesting that a valid and legitimate political subjectivity is only possible if it originates in a particular language or culture, Massad assumes that previous understanding of desires and identities possess a monolingual unity, to which Western taxonomies were inflicted upon. In this view, translation becomes an imposition to be suffered, rather than a process where multiple frames of intelligibility are negotiated. By tracing the

inauthenticity of modern lesbian and gay identities back to the historical shifts of the nineteenth and early twentieth centuries, Massad locates the failure of the Western medical regime in the act of translation itself.

A similar understanding of translation as failure can be found in Ottoman historian Dror Ze'evi's discussion of the transformation of sexual discourses at the turn of the century. Ze'evi (2006) claims that although European medical texts were translated into the Ottoman Empire in the nineteenth century, the scientific discourse on sexuality was neither accepted by society nor firmly embedded in the cultural milieu. Drawing on Foucault's (1978) critique of repressive hypotheses, he contrasts the situation in the West, where there has been a 'veritable discursive explosion' on sexuality, with the Middle Eastern and North African context: 'A long and continuous repression of sexual discourse, especially in the Ottoman period, turned into a 'dark abyss of sexual silence' as a result of colonialism' (Ze'evi 2005, 36). While Ze'evi's silence assumption has been questioned for dismissing nineteenth century medical discourse on sexuality (Kozma 2013), I would like to scrutinise his assumption that translation that cannot produce a discourse on sexuality. The principal reason Ze'evi addresses is the discrepancy between the one-sex model – or the model of woman as imperfect man – that continued to prevail in various fields and the two-sex model offered by the newly translated medical texts (Ze'evi 2006, 46). This line of argument rests on two assumptions: First, models that make desires, actions and subjectivities intelligible work only by superseding each other. Second, if the new coming model is translated, supersession will not succeed. A body of knowledge, terminology, or epistemology, when translated, remains a copy, incapable of capturing truly the romantic and erotic lives of the natives.

I align with Eve Kosofsky Sedgwick that models of love, eroticism and the body do not supersede each other and that definitions of love, erotic desire and sexual acts are structured by the unrationalised coexistence of the different models (1990, 47). Different models do not erase each other but coexist, often in tension and continuously inform one another. In contrast, the presumption of supersession relies on a particular representation of translation where languages are imagined as closed, autonomous entities with homogenous language communities and translation is the process of transferring meaning from one unitary language to another (Sakai 1997). When translation fails, resulting in a lack of comprehension, it is often attributed to the supposed discrepancies between languages. But in reality noncomprehension depends on this particular representation of translation: 'It is only retrospectively, and, in the final analysis, subsequent to the representation of translation, that we begin to figure out an experience of noncomprehension of an other's utterance according to the international schematism' (Sakai 1997, 7).

I join others who think that moving beyond such schmatism is necessary for queer and trans debates that are both enmeshed in and benefit from translation as a method, both in addressing contemporary political potentials and in questioning the genealogies of cis-heteropatriarchy and monolingual nationalism (Baer 2021, 4; Butler 2024; Savcı 2021).[3] But translation is also fraught with structural inequalities between languages, cultures, and epistemologies 'which means that [it] must be defined as a power struggle, also prevents assigning translation a single significance' (Casanova 2021, 410).

[3]For exploring the potentials of translation as a possible site for resistance in contemporary queer activism in Turkey please see Alan (2024); Duraner (2022).

In an age of decline, translation was considered as necessary for the late Ottoman Empire to keep up with the rapid changes in the literary and cultural scenes as well as in the scientific, legal and political realms. But translation was also associated with fears of losing one's identity, as originality was becoming key to aesthetic value and aesthetic authenticity was linked to questions about authenticity of the nation (Gürbilek 2003; Dolcerocca and Bozyer 2024, 3). These anxieties were intertwined with sexual anxieties; expressions of male homoeroticism were associated with Persian or sometimes Arabic language and culture, while the heterosexual ideal was framed in a language and epistemology deeply ingrained with Orientalist assumptions.

These historical tensions around translation – perceived as a necessary a tool of progress but also a threat to authenticity – continue to inform contemporary politics of sexuality, gender and national identity. Language and sexuality are intimately linked in the 'homolingual address' (Sakai 1997), not only through metaphors of hetero-patriarchal family such as the mother tongue, but also through being linked to the reproduction of the nations as a pure and separate entities – both biologically and culturally (Baer 2021; Yıldız 2012). Contrary to what monolingualism suggests both in critical accounts such as Massad's and Ze'evi and in contemporary right-wing anti-gender politics, various concepts of erotic life are rarely pure and touched; they are polyglot, emerging from the interaction of multiple languages and models of gender and sexuality. The erotic and medical vocabulary of Ottoman Turkish is an example of such linguistic hybridity shaped over centuries by translations from various languages – including Turkish, Persian, Arabic, Greek and others. Tracing the genealogies of linguistic and erotic hybridity and their translation at the turn of the century is an essential task for anti-imperialist queer critique against the current resurgence of anti-gender politics that disavow translation in its instrumentalisation of an anti-imperialist rhetoric while tapping into fantasies of linguistic, national and sexual purity.

Inventing and pathologising sexuality through translation

Although translations of complete books by sexologists were much later in the 1940s, names of European sexologists such as Richard von Krafft-Ebing, Carl Friedrich Otto Westphal, Havelock Ellis, Magnus Hirschfeld and Auguste Forel started to appear in Ottoman Turkish more widely at the turn of twentieth century. The neuropsychiatrists, of whom Raşid Tahsin (Tuğsavul), Mazhar Osman (Uzman), Nazım Şakir (Şakar), Fahreddin Kerim (Gökay), and Rasim Adasal were the most prominent, translated European – and mostly German – sexology and the categories of 'sexual perversions' into Ottoman and later modern Turkish in the early twentieth century.[4] While many of these medical doctors were politically and socially engaged during the establishment and development of the Republican regime, Mazhar Osman has arguably been the most influential in the formation of modern Turkish neuropsychiatry, having founded the first modern psychiatric institution in the Republic, Bakırköy Hospital and trained a majority of the first generation of neuropsychiatrists. *Tabâbet-i Ruhîye* can be considered his magnum opus,

[4]Nazım Şakir's *Aşk-ı Marazî* (Pathological Love) (1910–1911), which was published in installments, and Fahreddin Kerim's *Yorgun Sinirler ve Marazî Aşklar Üzerine Ruhî Tedkikler* (Psychic Examinations of Exhausted Nerves and Pathological Loves) (1928) were aimed at a popular readership. Raşid Tahsin addressed sexual pathologies in his book on neuropsychiatric training *Seririyât-ı Aklîye Dersleri* (1920).

published three times in 1909–1910, 1926 and 1941–1947 where he discussed sexological categories under the title 'sexual impulsions' in the first edition and 'sexual perversions' in the 1926 and 1941 editions. The first edition used two terms for 'sexual:' *tenâsülî*, derived from the Arabic root *nasala* (offspring/procreate), and *cinsî*, from the Arabic root *jins*[5] (kind/species), with the former gradually removed in later editions.

It has been historically documented how sexuality has sewed together elements that are not inherently connected such as 'different biological and mental possibilities, cultural forms, gender identity, bodily differences, reproductive capacities, needs, desires, fantasies, erotic practices, institutions, and values' (Weeks 2010, 7–8). This discursive entity was not created all at once and has never acquired a stable or consistent meaning. Through the gradual formation of sexuality in its translation, one can trace how multiple meanings were negotiated. The word *cinsî* had already acquired a sexual connotation in late nineteenth century; the *Lugât-i Tıbbiye* (Medical Dictionary) of 1873 gives two equivalents for sexual namely *tenâsülî* and *cinsî* while the equivalent for sex was *cins* (Lugât-i Tıbbiye 1873, 554-555). However, *cinsî* (or later *cinsel* with a modern Turkish suffix) did not become popular until the middle of the twentieth century while the word *tenâsül* was used more frequently in both medical and popular advice literature in the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries.[6] However, *tenâsül* was not suitable for expressing one's sex and Ottoman Turkish neologisms for homosexuality all included the root *cins* (*müteşâbihü'l-cins*, *müşâbihü'l-cins, mütecâni-s'ül-cins* – meaning similar sexes*)* in the earliest editions. This contributed to the gradual development of a concept of sexuality that encompassed one's sex.

The term *tenâsül*, in the sense of sexuality, was itself a relatively recent invention. Dealing with marital sexual activity within a scientific way was an important step in the process of translation of sexuality as *tenâsül*. Ottoman medical doctors and intellectuals found an outlet to communicate with the public in a scientific language through the advice books (Yılmaz 2017, 224). The idea that sexual matters within marriage needed to be discussed openly and scientifically for the nation's survival gradually shaped sexuality as a dark force with immense destructive powers (Foucault 1978). These powers, attributed to carnal desire – *arzu-i şehvaniye* – had to be brought under the control of reproductive sexual activity within marriage (Hatibzade Nusret [1329] 1913–1914, 29–30). Advice books not only drew the boundaries of legitimate carnal desire but also provided normative definitions of marital sexuality. For instance, medical doctor Hüseyin Remzi advised newlyweds to be moderate in the amount of sexual intercourse, since 'too much of the treatment of spouses' (*muamele-i zevciyenin ifratı ve tefriti*) could lead to 'the excessive consumption and waste of the important fluids that maintain the vitality of the body' ([1321] 1905–1906, 22–23). His book *Hıfz-ı Sıhhat-ı Müteehhilin* (Protective Health of the Married) illustrates the unrationalised coexistence of different regimes of sexuality since he uses European statistical data alongside a bleak account of the results of immoderate marital sexual activity within the tradition of humoral medicine. Advice books on sexual activity were not a nineteenth-century novelty, but what

[5]On how *jinsiyyah* acquired the meaning of sexuality in Arabic see Massad (2007, chapter 3); El-Rouayheb (2005, 158).
[6]*Tenâsül* was still in use in the middle of twentieth century. Krafft-Ebing's *Psychopatia Sexualis* was translated with the title *Tenâsül Hayatımızda Bozukluklar* (Disorders in Our Sexual/Reproductive Life) in 1941.

distinguished these books from early modern treatises – such as the *bâhnâme*[7] – was their treatment of the subject in the context of pronatalism, which was firmly rooted in the procreation meaning of *tenâsül*. For instance, the book *Hıfz-ı Sıhhat-i Tenâsül ve İzdivâc* [*Protective Health of Sexuality/ Reproduction and Marriage*] propagated a pronatalist rhetoric, defending state control over reproduction and childbirth (*tenâsül ve tevlidat*) since increased birth rates meant a stronger state (Ahmed Said 1308, 7–8).

In addition to marriage manuals, books on syphilis, gonorrhoea, impotence and infertility addressed sexual issues within a scientific framework. These books propagated pronatalism by targeting a Turkish-speaking Sunni Muslim population, as Muslim intellectuals were concerned about the growing population of non-Muslim minorities (Balsoy 2015, 20). Normative definitions of sexuality in this corpus of texts were linked to the idea of heredity. But there was an ambiguity of what could be passed on to the next generation (Balsoy 2015, 187–188), as degeneration became an umbrella term for 'a wide range of conditions, including epilepsy, sterility, sexual perversion, alcoholism and eccentricity' (Yanıkdağ 2013, 211) that could result from bachelorhood, prostitution, syphilis and alcoholism (Kılıç 2015, 117–134). In *Tabâbet-i Ruhîye* Mazhar Osman described sexual 'perversions' not only as a symptom of degeneration, but as the most important of all:

> These perversions can be regarded as the most important symptom of degeneracy (*araz-ı tereddî*) in a degenerate and they are as important to be considered as diseases in and of themselves. (Mazhar Osman 1926, 613–614)

The definition of sexual perversion as a degenerative, hereditary problem removed it from the social and political realm in which it was firmly embedded and established it as a congenital condition. For the translators of sexology, this shift was at the heart of the tensions between the two models of male same-sex sexuality that converged in their translations.

Inventing neologisms, finding equivalents

While there emerged a fairly coherent glossary in translating categories of 'sexual perversion' such as sadism or fetishism, there was a great terminological confusion and incoherency about male same-sex sexuality. This can be explained in part by the variety of terms used by European sexologists including paederast, invert, *uranist* and homosexual. There were significant differences in what these terms signified, and as the taxonomies of sexology were translated into Ottoman Turkish, heated debates about the etiology of same-sex desires and how to address them continued in German, English, and French. Despite the relentless pursuit of classification, sexology's definitions of homoerotic desires and subjectivities, continued to be unstable and incoherent. This was exacerbated by the collision of European taxonomies with Ottoman notions of homoerotic love and desire.

Sexological categories, like in other scientific fields, were borrowed and introduced in Latin script in Ottoman Turkish texts. Examining the foreign borrowings reveals how the politics of translation intertwined with imperial politics, shaping the spread of scientific knowledge and medical education. In the first edition of *Tabâbet-i Ruhîye*, Krafft-Ebing's

[7]The genre of *ilm el-bâh* was '"a mode of description of erotic and reproductive physiology and pharmacology'" (Downham Moore 2023) and falls within what Foucault defined as *ars erotica*. Patrick Franke highlights the connection between *ilm el-bâh* and medicine, noting that it focuses on sexual health rather than pathologies (Franke 2012, 163).

'*contraere sexualempfindung*' and the French '*sensibilité sexuelle contraire*' were included alongside '*Urning*' in Latin script (Mazhar Osman 1909, 263). Although he hadn't been to Germany yet at the time, Osman knew German psychiatry through his professor Raşid Tahsin. The first edition retained the French translation of the term 'contrary sexual feeling' due to French being the Ottoman medical lingua franca, but in later editions, he removed it and used the French '*homosexualité*', reflecting the term's growing international popularity in the 1920s and the shift in terminology across languages (Mazhar Osman 1926, 660). The neologism for same-sex sexuality '*müteşâbihü'l-cins*' was coined to cover all same-sex sexuality, regardless of gender, position, or age.[8] In the first edition, Mazhar Osman defined homosexuality as including *livâta* (sodomy) and *sahâka* – a term for female same-sex sexuality – and *mahbûbdostluk* which he dropped in the second edition. While he continued using terms like *mahbûbdost*/*mahbûbperest* and *gulâmperest* in the 1926 and 1947 editions, following the 1932 language reform he gradually replaced them with the Turkish equivalent of paederasty, *oğlancılık*.

Translators of sexology struggled to reconcile the minority model which understood same-sex sexuality as a congenital trait belonging to a minority with implications of gender transitivity, and the universalising model which dealt with acts, social structures and acquired traits that could belong to anyone (Sedgwick 1990). In Mazhar Osman's attempt to find equivalents for *uranism*, coined by Karl Heinrich Ulrichs,[9] the tension between these models, as well as the ones between carnality, active/passive roles became apparent. He claimed that while *gulâmperestlik* appears to be acquired, it actually is the result of a hereditary predisposition: the inability of young men to approach women in the Orient exacerbates pre-existing hereditary conditions (1909, 270). But for him, genetics was not able to explain why these men also liked to have sex with women. He writes the following in a passage in which he seeks to find an equivalent for *uranism*.

> As most German authors distinguished between *mahbûbperestlik* (Uranism) [in Latin script] and *livâta* (pederastie) [in Latin script], they pointed out a variety of differences between the two. *Mahbûbperestlik* is a congenital mental irregularity; an unnatural condition arising from inverted sexual [here *tenâsüli*] habits, the soul of a woman in the body of a man or the soul of a man in the body of a woman. Although *mahbûbperestî* urges [a person] to perform reverse sexual acts, this is not necessary. Normally, an *uranist* man is a chaste man. His only pleasure is to be dressed like a woman or to love a man like a woman, as he imagines. (Mazhar Osman 1909, 272)

The distinction between the sodomite and the *uranist*, as discussed by Mazhar Osman, corresponds to a key historical shift in the conceptualisation of same-sex sexuality, a transition from the temporary aberration of sodomy to the emergence of the homosexual as a 'species', as famously discussed by Foucault (1978, 43). While subsequent social constructivist queer historiography has traced the historical development of the homosexual, it has also faced criticism for imposing a rigid binary between acts and identities and for

[8]A much longer Turkish expression – love between those of the same sex (*aynı cinsten olanları aşkı*) – replaced these in the 1947 edition, when official language policy disfavored Arabic or Persian-derived words.

[9]Ulrichs, who studied law and worked as a civil servant in Hanover, was an opponent of Paragraph 175 of the Prussian law, which criminalized same-sex acts. Urning, a term he borrowed from Plato's Symposium, defined a third gender, 'a kind of man-woman; a female soul imprisoned in a male body' ('anima muliebris virili corpore inclusa') (Hekma 1996; Beachy 2010).

rigidifying the differences between modern/pre-modern and Western/non-Western sexual regimes.[10] In recent scholarship, however, dealing with the complexity of how different sexual acts, identities and models have interacted over time has become more prevalent.

Mazhar Osman's use of terms such as *mahbûbperestî*, *gulâmperestî* and *livâta* (sodomy) to make the unfamiliar model of minority more accessible is understandable, but his choices are somewhat unexpected and reveal the tension between two seemingly incompatible discourses on male same-sex sexuality. For example, *mahbûbperestî* lacks the gender transitivity associated with *uranism*, which Ulrichs defines as 'a woman's soul trapped in a man's body'. Terms such as *ibne* or *puşt*,[11] which Osman uses more frequently throughout the book despite their pejorative and unscientific connotations, might have been more appropriate choices, as they describe an adult male assuming a passive sexual role traditionally associated with femininity. However, in the passage where Osman is explicitly attempting to translate a term that denotes an identity, these terms – so closely associated with sexual acts – seem inappropriate. This tension helps to explain why Osman attributes chastity to uranism, even though it is not a central feature in European sexological texts. For Osman, the idea of maintaining an erotic identity without engaging in sexual activity seemed to require chastity, which in turn suggested a non-carnal form of male homoeroticism linked to *mahbûbperestî*.

The compound words *mahbûbperestî* and *gulâmperestî* were widely used to describe an adult man's love and interest in youthful boys[12] in the Turkish-speaking Ottoman Empire. Yet, as Selim Sırrı Kuru notes, these terms, often conflated in modern scholarship, were carefully distinguished by classical Ottoman authors. While *mahbûbperest* referred to a man 'testing his erotic longings by contemplating a younger male lover', *gulâmperest* satisfied his sexual urges through physical acts with young boys (Kuru 2020, 142). The key difference, then, lay in the role of carnality.[13] Although *uranism* had no explicit spiritual connotations, Mazhar Osman drew on the spiritual implications of *mahbûbperestî* because it was only through the framework of spiritual cross-generational homoerotic love, a category that sustained an identity without necessarily engaging in an act could become intelligible.

Although it continued to shape Mazhar Osman's framework of understanding while striving to find an equivalent, the distinction between the spiritual *mahbûbperestî* and the carnal *gulâmperestî* was already fading by the early twentieth century and Mazhar Osman himself used them interchangeably frequently in the rest of the text. The diminishing of the distinction between these terms can be traced back to long-term socio-political shifts from seventeenth century onwards, that prompted questioning a specific conceptualisation of love. In the eroto-politic configuration that rendered the love and adoration for the youthful boys (*mahbûb*s) intelligible, relationships between the beloved

[10]For a comprehensive review of these discussions please see Traub (2015, chapter 3).

[11]Former derived from the Arabic *ubnah* and the latter form the Persian *busht* (back). For a comprehensive discussion of these terms see Schick (2021); also see Ze'evi (2006, 38).

[12]For concerns about the cross-generational aspect of male homoeroticism within a scientific framework see Kayaal (2020); Atakan (2023).

[13]It should be noted that *mahbûbperest* is a compound of the Arabic-derived *mahbûb* (beloved) and the Persian-derived *perest* (worshipper), while *gulâmperest* combines the Arabic-derived *gulâm* (slave) with *perest*, suggesting that male slaves were more commonly seen as objects of carnal desire – and possibly non-consensual penetrative sex as a form of dominance – than the idealized object of poetic love, *mahbûb*.

mahbûb and his admirer poet, the slave and the master, the subject and the ruler – as the reflection of God on earth, mirrored each other (Andrews and Kalpaklı 2005). Coupled with the questioning of the Sultan's divine authority were the increasing criticism of heterodox Sufi practices such as contemplating the beauty of youthful boys as a religious practice and new and worldly forms of erotic expression that paved the way for a more profane definition of love (Artan and Schick 2013; Sarıtaş 2020; Ze'evi 2006; Zilfi 1986). In the early twentieth century, against the backdrop of the historical shift that combined the profane heterosexual love and reproductive activity under a modern conceptualisation of sexuality, spiritual love itself was started to be seen problematic by some. For instance, Nazım Şakir, another neuropsychiatrist who translated sexology's taxonomies, categorised this form of love as pathological, claiming true love requires balance between physiological and psychological aspects (Nazım [1326]1910–1911, 13).

Mahbûbperestî acquired perverse connotations not only in medical discussions, but perhaps more widely in the heated literary debates of the late Ottoman Empire and early Republican period.[14] The 'literature of wine and *mahbûb*' (*mey ve mahbûb edebiyatı*) was targeted for its repetitive themes expressed in an incomprehensible, embellished language full of Persian and Arabic words, revealing the overindulgence and elitism of classical Ottoman poets. Yet, the most perplexing aspect of *mahbûb* for its modern critics was his gender (Kuru 2006, 163). As new forms and aesthetic values, along with new moral values, gained a foothold in Ottoman literary and cultural spheres (Kuru 2007, 160), love for youthful boys was to be rejected, even if it was mystical, [15] because it was detached from the real world or carnal, [16] because the mystical dimension was perceived only as a closet of the poet's carnal homoerotic – and perverse – desires. Ömer Seyfettin, a nationalist author famous for his short stories, said the following in 1911–1912:[17]

> Those who think that the poets who composed turning their faces towards the Orient, with their praises, sighs, *gazels*[18] and tears usually address women, are as innocent as a child in the age of circumcision. (…) [You will] encounter terms such as *hat-aver, çar-ebru* [thinly – moustached, four-browed] which today's generation possibly does not even know the meaning of; and you will find some distasteful metaphors quite disgusting and immoral. (cited in Abdullah 1953, 200)

The widespread critique of classical Ottoman poetry in favour of a new and national literature led to the removal of the 'literature of wine and *mahbûb*' from the curricula of higher schools after the foundation of the Republic (*Akşam* 1934, 2). Around the same time, *mahbûb* – along with other terms – appeared on the list of words to be replaced by 'pure' Turkish equivalents in the daily newspapers. The elimination of the *mahbûb* from both literature and language was part of the effort to create a monolingual and heterosexual Turkish nation. Arabic and Persian, along with minority languages, were often

[14]For a review of these debates see Ergişi (2012, 103–106); Kahraman (1996, 272–282); Özdemir (2010, 326–332).

[15]The assumption that carnal and mystical love are mutually exclusive and the latter could not have an erotic dimension curtails a nuanced understanding of lyrical poetry. According to Anna Maria Schimmel the ambiguity and oscillation between the profane and the mystical is deliberately maintained in Persian and Ottoman poetry, thus it is futile to look for a purely profane or mystical interpretation (Schimmel 1975, 288; 300).

[16]For an example, see the letters between Ahmed Midhat and Muallim Naci (2011, 61–62).

[17]For a nuanced reading of Seyfettin's critique of the Persianate influence in condemning male homoeroticism in classical Ottoman poetry see Blackthorne (2024).

[18]A popular form of lyric poetry composed of couplets.

portrayed as foreign influences that had corrupted the national language, literature, and sexuality (Blackthorne-O'Barr 2024). Yet they have not completely disappeared from contemporary Turkish and different languages contributed to the translation process in distinct ways. Arabic-derived terms such as *tenâsülî* and *cinsî* were incorporated into the scientific language on sexuality, while Arabo-Persian compounds and Persian-derived words like *mahbûbdost*, *gulâmperest*, and *puşt* entered modern Turkish primarily as derogatory terms. In contrast, Romani – and to a lesser extent, Greek – contributed to queer slang, *lubunca* (Kontovas 2012). The divergent trajectories of the terms highlight the distinct roles various languages played in shaping Ottoman Turkish: classical scientific texts were mostly translated from Arabic; Persian was associated with the poetic canon – which, along with Ottoman classical literature, became increasingly marginalised – and minority languages remained vital to the vibrant urban subcultures.

While translation of sexology intersected with the the drive to create a monolingual Turkish nation, it simultaenously destabilised the development of a monolingual sexual vocabulary by introducing 'foreign' taxonomies. Though this historical transformation might be seen as evidence of the erasure of a rich indigenous erotic glossary through the imperial imposition of European concepts, nostalgic yearning for a lost past obscures our understanding of the myriad linguistic, textual and personal exchanges that took place in the emergence of a new – and incoherent – language. As the modern concept of sexuality gradually took shape through translation, it linked reproductive and mental capacities, desires, institutions, and acts in unprecedented ways within the framework of nationalism; while also opening up possibilities for its own destabilization (Sarıtaş 2020).

As part of these exchanges, sexological categories began to permeate the language of literary criticism. In 1933, the poet and critic Halit Fahri Ozansoy said: 'The homosexuality in Nedim's [work] could be a theme for H. Lenormand, "L'homme et ses Fantomes" … If you read it, you will see that it was such a tragedy of the soul, a misery' (cited in Kahraman 1996, 272). As the newly emerging pathological understandings of sexuality provided the critics of classical Ottoman literature with new concepts, literature provided the translators of sexology with readily available examples. Mazhar Osman, like Ozansoy, commented on the relationship between homosexuality and literature by drawing parallels with European literature. After mentioning the hardships of 'European poets afflicted with homosexuality, such as Oscar Wilde', he continued:

> Wine and *mahbûb* were also the only resource of Iranian and Turkish poets. The poets who dedicated *gazels* to the shaved skins of the *mahbûb* were a badge of honor for the Orient. In the Orient, being passive is considered a form of prostitution and dishonor. Whereas the active are proud of their deeds. ([Uzman] 1926, 674)

The conceptual traffic between literature and science reveals the complex processes of discursive formation of sexual knowledge and how fiction and fact; fantasy, narrative and science were intertwined (Schaffner 2012, 23). While the *mahbûb* served as a figure to translate the category of *uranist*, it also tapped into associations raised by literary criticism, such as the *mahbûb*'s spirituality being a closet for the poet's carnal desires. This surfaces in the above quote when Mazhar Osman alludes to sexual roles immediately after mentioning poets' devotion to *mahbûb*s.

Although mahbûbperestî was increasingly despised by intellectuals from diverse circles in the late Ottoman Empire, it did not signify an innate condition, as suggested

by the minority model, but rather an outdated, decadent social practice – a 'social pathology' in the absence of what Afsaneh Najmabadi (2005) calls 'compulsory heterosocialization'. As early as the mid-nineteenth century, the prominent statesman and historian Cevdet Pasha, commented on the displacement of the erotic attraction of youthful boys by the new interest in women as objects of desire (Ahmet Cevdet Paşa 1980, 10). In the decades that followed, the critique of gender segregation as the cause of same-sex sexuality was taken up by intellectuals in various disciplines. Mazhar Osman, among others who translated the categories of same-sex sexuality, effectively shared the critique of gender segregation. Since they did not completely agree politically and epistemologically with the implications of the minority model, translators of sexology attempted to navigate a middle ground. The result was what Baer describes as 'a kind of false synchrony, where works of sexology from different schools and time periods were brought together' (2015, 116).

With the foundation of the Republic and the official abolition of gender segregation, homosexuality, understood as a congenital condition as the predominant form of same-sex sexuality, came to be seen as a marker of a civilisational stage. This was articulated in Magnus Hirschfeld's framework of civilisational stages of homosexuality, where Turkey 'evolved' from the 'naïve tolerance' of homosexuality during the Ottoman period to a modern intolerance (Marhoefer 2022, 48–49). Fahreddin Kerim Gökay, who later became governor and deputy of İstanbul, said Republican revolutions ended the unnatural habit of excluding women from public life, which led to an increase in sodomy. Today in İstanbul, he continued, as in Europe, homosexuals are encountered only among the degenerate individuals who suffer from an innate and unchangeable deviance (Fahreddin Kerim 1928, 62–63). Mazhar Osman, in the first post-Republican edition of *Tabâbet-i Ruhîye*, echoed this stance complaining that in the imperial times it was not possible for a man to sit with his wife in public spaces, while he could be openly with boys in gardens, taverns, and baths. While a morbid germ in a man could easily flourish into a full-blown pathology under these conditions, he claimed, natural love began to emerge with the establishment of the Republic (Mazhar Osman 1926, 668).

However, having been born and raised in the Ottoman Empire, translators of sexology had to reckon with its legacy; a tension surfaced in highlighting an erotic – and social – hierarchy between active and passive sexual roles. As noted above, Mazhar Osman alludes to the passive role being considered shameful in the Orient, an argument prevalent at the time. The oscillation between the minority model, where roles did not matter and a universalising one resulted in an inconsistent sexological vocabulary. In the two post-Republic editions of *Tabâbet-i Ruhîye*, the most common word for male homosexuals was *puşt* alongside *ibne* both of which, as mentioned earlier, had strong pejorative connotations. Osman's preference for these words in a medical text seems to reflect his reluctance to fully embrace the minority model, which advocated for greater understanding and tolerance of a congenital condition. Notably, he uses *pederastie* as an equivalent for sodomy (*livâta*), while in other sections, he refers to sodomite (*lûti*) as a figure of gender inversion. He did not develop, or perhaps even wished to develop, a consistent or systematic vocabulary in his work, which went through three editions.

İbne, puşt, mahbûbdost, gulâmperest, lûti as well as others such as *hünsa*, (hermaphrodite) and *mabûn* (similar to *ibne*) frequently used in *Tabâbet-i Ruhîye* were among the immense plethora of words in Ottoman Turkish that defined various erotic types,

desires and acts. Irvin Cemil Schick says that in a project to compile an Ottoman Turkish erotic dictionary, over 650 words in sources from the mid-fourteenth to the mid-nineteenth centuries were identified (Schick 2021, 89). These words were the products of centuries of circulation and translation of literary and scientific texts as well as oral exchange, which made the Ottoman erotic glossary polyglot. With the exception of *puşt*, *ibne*[19] and *kulampara* derived from *gulâmperest*, that became swear words, the Ottoman erotic glossary gradually disappeared from Turkish and turned into an obscurity, a process exacerbated by the Romanisation of the script.

Encounters with European sexology as a scene of translation

To keep pace with the advancement of modern scientific knowledge, the Ottoman state funded scholarships for students to study in European countries, with the expectation that they would return to assume roles in the newly established higher education institutions within the Empire. The selection of the sexology literature to be translated, the approaches adopted and the terminology used were influenced, in part, by the medical specialisation of the translators and their educational backgrounds. One of the earliest translations of sexology literature was Auguste Ambroise Tardieu's *Assaults on Morals, Meaning Assault and Violation of Honor and Material Signs of Sodomy and Pederasty* in 1882–1883 (Tardieu 1298/1882–1883). The translation was a contribution to the curriculum of the Imperial School of Medicine by İbrahim Şevki, who was among the students sent to Europe after the founding of Mekteb-i Tıbbiye in 1827 and studied forensic medicine with Tardieu (Aykut 2019).[20] In *Assaults on Morals,* Tardieu studied sodomy (translated as *livâta)* and pederastie (translated as *ebânet)* within the framework of an older model of sexual transgression, which dealt with acts and effects, as opposed to the minority model which dealt with identities and causes (Hekma 1996, 216). The minority model was developed mainly by German medical scientists such as Krafft-Ebing, Westphal and Hirschfeld and Ottoman Turkish neuropsychiatrists, many of whom studied medicine in Germany translated this literature. The transnational popularity of this model, had a more profound impact on the translation of sexology than the exchange of ideas and theories within the imperial networks of scientific education.

In the first half of the nineteenth century, France was the main destination for students sent abroad, but towards the end of the century, the focus of the Ottoman state shifted to Germany, mainly due to the increasing political influence of Germany over the Ottoman Empire. Raşid Tahsin was sent to Germany to study with Emile Kraepelin, a leading German psychiatrist whose descriptive psychiatry had a profound impact on Ottoman-Turkish neuropsychiatry (Kılıç 2015, 7). Upon his return Tahsin was appointed as the teacher of mental and neurological diseases and clinics, where he trained other neuropsychiatrists such as Mazhar Osman. Mazhar Osman learned

[19]*İbne* has been reappropriated as part of Turkey's queer slang, *lubunca*, and now stands alongside English terms like 'queer' in both every day and political contexts. This coexistence paves the way for a critique of linguistic imperialism, without the fear of a multilingual world. For a current discussion see Butler (2023).

[20]İbrahim Şevki also translated the diaries of Herculine Barbine with a preface by Tardieu and serialized them in the newspaper *Tercümân-ı Hakîkat* owned by the prolific writer Ahmed Midhat. This text was introduced to Latinized Turkish thanks to historian Ebru Aykut. See Aykut (2019).

about German psychiatry from Tahsin, himself travelled to Germany and studied with Kraepelin, encouraged his students such as Fahreddin Kerim and Nazım Şakir to do the same.

Interestingly, Kraepelin opposed the notion of homosexuality as an innate condition, initially defended by Ulrichs and Krafft-Ebing, and later by Hirschfeld, instead promoted 'a seduction hypothesis'. He argued that youth should be protected from the 'seductive' influence of homosexuality, blaming the spread of 'sexual aberrations' on Magnus Hirschfeld and his Scientific-Humanitarian Committee (Kraepelin 1918, 119), which advocated against criminalising male same-sex acts in Germany. Kraepelin supported his hypothesis with claims about the widespread prevalence of homosexuality in Eastern countries, where heterosocial interactions were limited (Kraepelin 1918, 118; 1922, 52). While Kraepelin's views could have served as a valuable source for the Ottoman Turkish neuropsychiatrists grappling with the implications of minority model, there is little evidence that they engaged with the seduction hypothesis. Ottoman Turkish neuropsychiatrists who studied with Kraepelin before World War I were perhaps unaware of his hypothesis, as he distanced himself from Hirschfeld's progressive views only after the war (Mildenberger 2007, 325). The absence of Kraepelin's discussion of homosexuality in the Ottoman-Turkish translation of sexology demonstrates the limited influence of Kraepelin's approach on the transnational circulation of sexological ideas not only temporally (Mildenberger 2007, 332), but also geographically. In contrast, the minority model had a far broader and more enduring effect on the transnational dissemination of sexological thought, despite all the discursive incoherencies it created.

Nevertheless, a channel through which Ottoman scientists participated the formation of a transnational sexological knowledge was through Kraepelin. In an effort to address the issue of degeneration through widespread psychiatric observation and data that transcended national boundaries, Kraepelin called for an international conference in Berlin in 1910 – the *Fourth International Congress for the Care of the Mentally Ill* (Engstrom 2016, 117). Raşid Tahsin attended the conference, presenting epidemiological data from the Ottoman Empire. In the conference proceedings, he said:

> I have encountered active and passive, congenital and acquired sodomites among the Greeks. In second place come the Persians and later the Jews. Among the Muslims, the disease rarely occurs. In clinical observation, I have come across a few cases to whom the disease was inflicted (Raşid [1326] 1911, 31–32; 1911, 516–517)

Without getting into the debates about whether the 'disease' is congenital or acquired, he externalised it from the Sunni Muslim identity, most likely because he addressed a European audience. This outright denial of same-sex practices among the Sunni population supports the scholarly claims about the effects of Europeans' perception on public manifestations of male homoerotic desire as inducing shame and silence (Arvas 2014, 157; Avcı 2017, 772–773; Ze'evi 2006, 164). There is ample evidence to support this argument; Cevdet Pasha continued his remarks on changing trends of love and courtship by commenting on how famous *mahbûbperest* pashas hid their admiration for youthful boys because they felt intimidated by the objections of foreigners.[21]

[21]For a critical reading of this quote see Delice (2012).

Iranian and Arab modernisers also condemned expressions of homoerotic desire in their classical literature in the face of 'homo-Orientalist' depictions (Boone 2015; El-Rouayheb 2005; Massad 2007; Najmabadi 2005). However, as exemplified in Tahsin's quote, the shame induced by Orientalist representations, played a role in shaping a cis-heteropatriarchal national identity rather than leading to an 'abyss of silence' (Ze'evi 2005, 36). Unlike his professor, Mazhar Osman admits that Turks could also engage in male same-sex activities but expresses this within a racialised sexual hierarchy: '*Puşt*s are common among the Turks, Greeks, Armenians and Jews of our land. Male prostitutes are preferably Greek boys. Although there are some active ones among the Greeks, being passive is prevalent and a source of income' (Mazhar Osman 1926, 673).

In putting sexological terminology into use for defining a masculine heterosexual national identity, translators had to grapple with the homo-Orientalist assumptions deeply ingrained in European sexology (Boone 2015; Marhoefer 2022). The lack of a Turkish translation[22] of Magnus Hirschfeld's *The Homosexuality of Man and Woman* (1914), as well as its relative neglect in comparison to his *Berlin's Third Sex* (1904) – a title disdainfully translated by Mazhar Osman as *Berlin Puştları/Hünsaları* in *Tâbabet-i Rûhiye* – may be due to Hirschfeld's reference to Istanbul as an example of an 'Urning colony'. This colony, he noted, consisted of Europeans from Austria, France, Germany and England who had emigrated to seek pleasure without fearing legal repercussions or prejudice, since 'what was condemned as vice in the West was considered merely taste in the East' (Hirschfeld 1914, 448).

Turkey may indeed have been a safer alternative for some when compared to Germany, where Paragraph 175 which punished male same-sex acts was in force at the turn of the century. Yet, this does not negate the fact that their motivations may have been shaped by homo-Orientalist assumptions.[23] In outlining his minority model of homosexuality, Hirschfeld drew on accounts of men he knew through homosexual political circles in Germany who lived in non-Western countries, using their experiences as data on these regions (Marhoefer 2022, 41). While for eighteenth- and nineteenth-century Orientalists the account of tolerance for homoeroticism was a sign of the sexual alterity of the Orient (Boone 2015; Schick 1999), for sexual emancipators like Hirschfeld it was evidence of a congenital and universal homosexuality common to all humanity.

In *The Homosexuality of Man*, Hirschfeld mentions that through a young Armenian *bey* and a Turkish doctor of in İstanbul and in Bursa, he had the opportunity to know some Muslim homosexuals, some of whom showed traits of femininity (Hirschfeld 1914, 598.) Who these physicians were remains to be revealed by further research, but there is mention of a Ludwig Adler (Bey)[24] from Istanbul who was active in sexology circles of Hirschfeld in Berlin. He gave a lecture on 'The Sexual Life of Eunuchs with Special Reference to Homosexuality' at a meeting of the Scientific-Humanitarian Committee in 1914 (W.-h. Komittee 1914, 249). Adler Bey also wrote a paper for sexologist

[22]Until recently, *The World Journey of a Sexual Scientist* was his only book translated into Turkish as *Cinsiyet Dünyası* (*The World of Sexuality*) (Hirschfeld 1946).

[23]Further research on the renowned Orientalist scholar Hellmut Ritter, who emigrated to Istanbul after being charged in Germany with violating Paragraph 175 will substantiate this claim. See Hergemöller (2010, 986–987).

[24]So far, I have not located any biographical information about Ludwig Adler Bey. Although the lifetime of the Austrian gynecologist Ludwig Adler coincides with his, there is no evidence to suggest that he visited Istanbul for any professional purpose. See Rudloff and Ludwig (2005).

Iwan Bloch's *Zeitschrift für Sexualwissenchaft* about prostitution in Istanbul, in which he countered homo-Orientalist assumptions by saying that male prostitution was not as high as it was claimed in Europe and that after the Young Turk Revolution the number of male brothels had fallen to four (Adler Bey 1914-5, 73).

While it is not yet possible to determine the conditions under which Adler Bey participated in the production of sexological knowledge, it can be said that scholars from non-European backgrounds, such as Raşid Tahsin and Mazhar Osman, did not participate in the transnational networks of sexology on equal terms, but rather through the asymmetrical relationships of imperialist knowledge production: European scholars trained 'Oriental' scholars, who then contributed data for the production of imperialist knowledge, occasionally shaping the data to fit pre-existing assumptions. At the same Berlin conference, Raşid Tahsin's data confirmed the formula of 'syphilization and civilization' and claimed that general paresis, a neuropsychiatric disorder that occurs in the later stages of syphilis, is more common among people of intellect and thus among the more civilised peoples of the West (Raşid 1911). Raşid Tahsin was an exception among Turkish speaking medical circles, however, in that he accepted this medical Orientalist hypothesis, which was quickly taken up in European medical circles after its formulation by Krafft-Ebing. Others, such as Mazhar Osman, challenged this formula, pointing out that it was based on overgeneralised stereotypical representations of the Turkish/Eastern people that were informed by Orientalist prejudices and clouded scientific objectivity (Yanıkdağ 2013, 157; 2018; Artvinli 2014, 132–133). In the last edition of *Tabâbet-i Ruhîye,* Mazhar Osman said he has been among the critics of the relationship established between general paresis and civilisation for more than thirty years (Uzman 1941, 262). Undoubtedly, his criticism of 'syphilization and civilization', formula was nationalistically motivated; but it was also based on epidemiological data and clinical observations. However, as I have tried to detail, nationalists faced a more complicated task in challenging homo-Orientalist narratives, where empirical observation and data collection were more difficult.

Lands of tolerance or persecution

Although homosexuality in the form of an inborn condition of a sexual minority was accepted as a sign of civilisation for the Ottoman Turkish translators of sexology, neither activism for it nor its public expressions were welcomed. As German sexology was translated into Turkish, one of the 'unsurprising effects' was that Germany – and Berlin in particular-was portrayed as the hotbed of this new form of homosexuality (Beachy 2010, 828). A popular sexology book of the 1930s asserted that there was no other city where homosexual relations (*hemcinsçilik münasebetleri*) were as ubiquitous as in Berlin (A.M. 1933, 212):

> Although some European writers regard the Orient as an important source of it, in reality the writers of the West have no longer any right to condemn the Orientals in this respect, since these ugly habits are now more popular in European countries, especially among the gentry. (A.M. 1933, 221)

Translators of sexology were appalled by Ulrichs' activism and scorned Hirschfeld's Committee, yet they also recognised how Nazi rule had destroyed it. In 1941 Rasim

Adasal, the youngest in the lineage of neuropsychiatrists who translated sexological categories, acknowledged the existence of 'unnatural love associations some years ago', referring to the Committee while noting 'public defense of such pathological tendencies was no longer possible in Hitler's Germany' (Adasal 1941, 3).

During the war, Turkey became a refuge for many German-speaking individuals, primarily scientists and intellectuals fleeing the Nazi regime; however, the experiences of those with non-conforming gender and sexualities still require further research. In 1941 Mazhar Osman gave a public lecture, which was later published, under the title 'Superior Degenerates' where he talked about a transfeminine person, Lareine, who had fled Nazi Vienna for Istanbul (Uzman 1942, 223). Alongside the published lecture and later in the third edition of *Tabâbet-i Ruhîye,* some pictures of Lareine were included (Figures 1 and 2). Lareine must have fled Vienna to escape Nazi rule after annexation in 1938 as a news story about her appeared in a Turkish newspaper in January 1939 (Bora 1939, 6). According to Mazhar Osman he was recommended to Lareine by Rudolf Nissen, a German surgeon who also fled to Turkey from Hitler's rule (Uzman 1942, 223). Although Nissen was specialised in thoracic surgery, he was also referred to as a specialist of sexual disorders (*Vakit* 1933, 6). It is likely that this specialisation made him a point of contact for transnational sexology networks and drew Lareine, who also was involved in such circles, to Nissen.

Figure 1. Image from the published lecture 'High Degenerates' (Mazhar Osman 1942, 223).

Figure 2. 'Tronsvestit [sic.] – Lareine a man in woman's clothes [sic.]' Tababet-i Ruhiye (1947).

Mazhar Osman describes Lareine as an elegant Viennese lady in silk stockings, her hands well-groomed and adorned with jewelry. He took pride in conversing with this 'blue-eyed brunette' in German, quoting Lareine's words on how she[25] took great pleasure in looking so much as a woman and apologised for 'deceiving him' (Uzman 1942, 223). Lareine introduces herself as a transvestite and wonders if Mazhar Osman could help her to wear women's clothes in public in Istanbul without police intimidation.

Lareine,[26] a Viennese – born performer, performed a 'transformation act' (*Verwandlungsnummer*) in the 1920s and 1930s in Viennese clubs and halls, changing costumes to 'trans' between genders (*Das Kino Journal* 1933, 15; *Der Wiener Tag* 1933, 12). She says she toured Turkey in addition to England, Italy, France and the Netherlands before the war (*Voorwaarts* 1931; *Die Stunde* 1933, 3). Since she had been to Turkey, a destination for many fleeing the Nazi regime, it might have seemed like a place where she could try to live and work safely during the war. She reported to hold a certificate that Hirschfeld's Sexual Research Institute had issued identifying her as a transwoman (*Die Stunde* 1933, 3). She was probably looking for a sympathetic sexologist like Hirschfeld in İstanbul who could help her with a similar document. However, she ended up in the office of Mazhar Osman, who reported that Lareine eventually left Istanbul because it was not

[25]As she indicated in an interview that she was born and felt like a woman, I use the pronouns she/her for Lareine (*Die Stunde* 1933, 3).
[26]Little is known about Lareine in academic and activist circles in Vienna, where I did some preliminary research.

Figure 3. Still image from the movie Mysterium des Geschlechtes (1933).

possible for 'a psychiatric freak' (*ruhi ucube*) like her to walk around in İstanbul in women's clothes (Uzman 1941, 224).[27]

Lareine stars and performs her V*erwandlungsnummer* in the 1933 movie *Mysterium des Geschlechtes*[28] about gender affirmation surgeries (Figure 3). Much less is known about Lareine's biography when compared to other well-known transgender people who appear in the movie such as Charlotte Charlaque and Toni Ebel. Jonah Garde, a researcher on Lareine, suggests that her relatively limited involvement in sexological circles accounts for her marginal presence in the field (personal conversation, 13 September 2023).[29] Upon learning that I encountered Lareine in a text on sexology, Garde reassessed their initial assumptions, although I think that these assumptions remain largely unchallenged. The inclusion of Lareine in *Tabâbet-i Rûhiye*, along with Mazhar Osman's other works, remains peripheral to the broader body of transnational sexological knowledge. Despite their participation in transnational sexology networks, Ottoman Turkish scholars were primarily tasked with contributing data on 'Oriental' sexualities, thus reinforcing the racialised underpinnings of sexological knowledge production. As the category of transvestite was coined by Hirschfeld in his 1910 book *Die Transvestiten*, the imperial knowledge on non-Western transgenderism was at the heart of his work (Marhoefer 2022, 53). By translating the category of transvestite into Turkish through a

[27]Lareine might have survived the war, since someone by the same name performed Vienna as the 1940s drew to a close (*Weltpresse* 1949; 1950).

[28]Although it is certain that Lareine must have had some connection to Vienna's sexology circles in order to participate in the film, the exact nature of these connections remains unknown. In addition to the sexology archives, such as those of the Scientific-Humanitarian Committee and the Institute for Sexual Research in Vienna, the details of the film's production did not survive the Nazi regime and the war. See Bauer (2017).

[29]Please see Garde (2026).

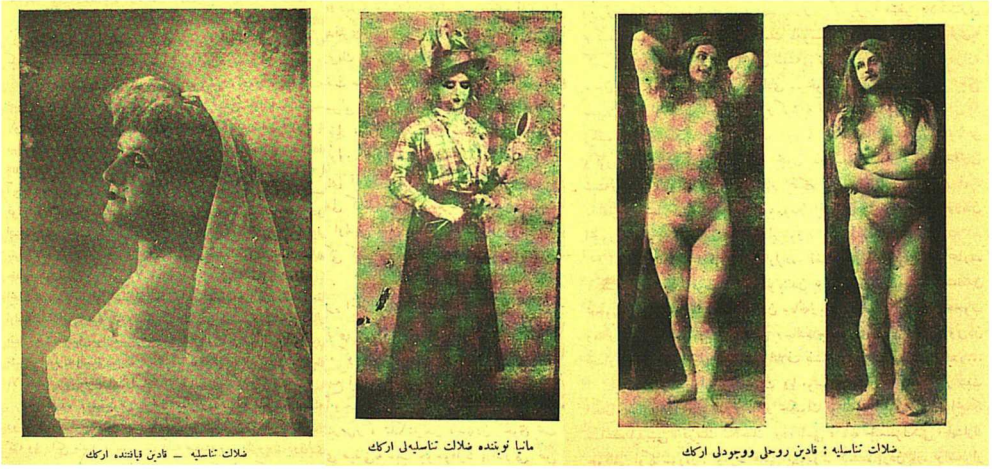

Figure 4. Images of gender non-conforming people from *Tabâbet-i Ruhîye* (1926).

European subject, Mazhar Osman reversed the division of labour in imperialist knowledge production, but his transphobic nationalist pride for the emerging cis-heteropatriarchal culture of the Turkish Republic against a transgender refugee makes this reversal anything but subversive.

Mazhar Osman had a long-standing interest in photography (Behmoaras 2001) and included patient photographs in the 1926 edition of *Tabâbet-i Ruhîye*. These images featured gender non-conforming individuals, accompanied by captions such as 'sexual perversion (*dalâlet-i tenâsüliye*) – a man dressed as a woman', 'a man with sexual perversion in a manic episode', and 'a man with the body and soul of a man', while the text also utilised the category 'transvestit' ([Uzman] 1926, 589; 600-601) (Figure 4).[30]

When Lareine's photographs were included in the 1947 edition to provide further visual scientific evidence for the 'transvestite', the moment was not only marked by Mazhar Osman's interest in photographing patients, but also the 'beginnings of a more comprehensive turn toward the visual within scientific sex research' (Sutton 2018, 454). But Lareine's images were not produced by the medical pathologising lens; they belonged to Lareine herself, seemingly taken in a studio (Figure 5). As Katie Sutton says, while sexologists and psychiatrists turned to photography in the early twentieth century as scientific evidence in the diagnosis of the 'transvestite', photography also served as 'a kind of self-representation that emerged in the German 'third sex' subcultural context' in the late Weimar period, as exemplified by the magazine *Das 3. Geschlecht* (Sutton 2018). Lareine's first appearance corresponds to the period of the magazine's publication (1930–1932) and her highly stylised photographs seem to belong to this trend. It is not clear whether Lareine gave permission to Mazhar

[30]I would like to thank Tuğba Taş for pointing out the striking similarity between the rightmost of these images and another image in a book containing Mazhar Osman's collection of photographs (Erkoç and Yazıcı 2006, 86–87). Unfortunately, despite our efforts to contact the editors, Tuğba Taş and I were unable to locate the original photographs. Both images depict the individuals in a nude pose, while one has short hair and is diagnosed with hysteria. The striking facial and physical resemblance raises the question of whether the images belong to the same person, suggesting some of the photographs in Mazhar Osman's collection may have been deliberately staged.

Figure 5. Photographs of Lareine from Mazhar Osman's collection published in Erkoç and Yazıcı (2006).

Osman to share her photos at will, but these photos where she demonstrates 'a conscious self-staging' (Sutton 2018, 457) in elegant dresses and alluring poses stand in stark contrast to the photos of other patients being involuntarily exposed to an ethically questionable medicalised gaze.

By publishing Lareine's photographs and story, Mazhar Osman has contributed, albeit unintentionally, to the circulation of a glimpse of a subculture to which Lareine belonged

in Vienna and likely Istanbul, as well as a visual agency that escaped the medical gaze. This moment demonstrates that the translation of sexology is not a simple transmission of regulatory scientific taxonomies, but a complex, multi-layered process in which the travel of concepts is intermingled with that of people and carries in itself the potentials of the subversion of pathologising discourses.

Conclusion

The language used in *Tabâbet-i Ruhîye* to address sexual and gender non-conformity is far from settled or consistent. Different terms are employed throughout the text and these variations are not clarified; something not expected from a scientific text revised and published three times by one of the most renowned medical doctors of his time. Throughout the process of writing of this paper, I also found myself struggling to develop and maintain a consistent use of terminology, juggling terms from Turkish, Arabic, Persian, German, and Latin. Our common inability to maintain a consistent vocabulary parallels something that Paisley Currah observes about his monograph *Sex Is Sex Does*: the ongoing battle over the meanings of sexual and gender identities, acts, desires and representations prevents making static definitions and developing a consistent language (2022, xvi). Read intertextually, *Tabâbet-i Ruhîye* allows us to explore how different understandings and conceptualisations of sexuality and gender identity from various periods and geographies – each shaped by centuries of translations – clash and result in unresolved tensions. In the process of forming a scientific understanding of sexuality, translation has contributed to these tensions, while also offering an insight into the incoherencies of the various categories we use to define non-conforming sexualities and genders.

In Turkey, the lives of those with non-conforming sexualities and genders are increasingly at risk of persecution as legislation targeting LBGTI + communities – especially gender non-conforming individuals – and organisations are actively developed by both the government and its ultra-Islamist coalition partners (Özgenç 2025a; 2025b). Framed as a defense against 'global' forces allegedly aiming to destroy national morality and family, these efforts mobilise a nostalgic desire for fixed identities and stable names free from any 'foreign' influence; yet the past this nostalgia yearns for is a phantasm that fuels fascist tendencies (Butler 2024, 8). Such tendencies seek to reverse the emerging multilingual transnational context in which struggles over meaning and language coincide with struggles over gender identity and sexuality. Against this backdrop, as Judith Butler suggests, 'suffering' translation might become a tool to break what Derrida calls 'monolingual obstinacy:'

> The task, as it were, is to break out of monolingualism by suffering the humilities of translation, to refuse the implicit nationalism implied by a singular and hegemonic language, and to reach, and be reached by, a broader world, one that is multilingual and multisyntactical, and where the linguistic conditions of livability always differ. (Butler 2024, 238)

Revisiting the multilayered histories of twentieth-century translation – where multiple languages and desires coexisted in tension – has a critical potential for challenging the anti-imperialist rhetoric of anti-gender politics. Such an analysis foregrounds that exposing the unequal conditions under which languages circulate does not necessitate a nationalist retreat into monolingual unity.

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